

# Aircraft placard & instrument typefaces — specimen

Four lineages compared. Every face is the real font [named at right]; captions give the standard it represents.

1 • Modern glass-cockpit screen

Airbus + ENAC — open-sourced 2017 [OFL]

AIRSPEED

120.300 SQ 1200

AVIONICS MASTER • FUEL PUMP • PITOT HEAT • STARTER

120 KT 29.92 IN 5500 FT N428PS

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

Built for cockpit *displays* — legibility under glare & vibration; shown with B612 Mono. — [B612](#)

2 • U.S. military instrument panels

MIL-M-18012 printed markings [now SAE AS18012]

AIRSPEED

AVIONICS MASTER • FUEL PUMP • PITOT HEAT • STARTER

120 KT 29.92 IN 5500 FT N428PS

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

An approved printing face [with Futura Demibold]. Engraved panels use **Gorton** — see p.2. — [News Gothic](#)

3 • WWII-era aircraft lettering

RAF “Spartan” — a Futura/geometric relative

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120 KT 29.92 IN 5500 FT N428PS

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

1940s geometric letterforms; Renner’s Futura is the same family. — [Spartan](#)

4 • RAF 851ATH & modern GA silk-screen

Condensed grotesque — homebuilt/GA placards

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ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

RAF 851ATH ~ Helvetica Medium Condensed; today’s GA shops cut condensed-gothic placards like this. — [Trade Gothic Cond](#)

**Gorton** [engraved-panel face, MIL-M-18012] is compared with News Gothic on page 2. **Futura** [Renner] and **Spartan** are the same geometric family. U.S. exterior stencils used the USAAF ~45° [“Amarillo”] and USN ~30° [“LongBeach”] forms. Panelsmith now sets instruments in B612; placards offer B612 / a condensed gothic / Spartan.

# Engraved vs. printed — Gorton & News Gothic

Both serve U.S. military panels under MIL-M-18012, but for different processes — and they look it. Same words, two faces.

Printed / silk-screened — News Gothic

MIL-M-18012 approved printing face

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A **printer's gothic**: subtly modulated stroke weights, two-storey “a”/“g”, drawn for reading on a printed scale or placard. — [News Gothic](#)

Engraved — Gorton

The machine-engraving alphabet [MIL-M-18012 engraving]

AIRSPEED

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I20 KT 29.92 IN 5500 FT N428PS

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

A **machine-engraving** alphabet: constant-width *monoline* strokes and squarish forms a pantograph/CNC cutter can follow — the classic mid-century instrument-panel look. Shown via the open “Gorton Digital” revival [drdnar]. — [Gorton](#)

**Why they differ:** News Gothic is a typographic printing face; **Gorton** is an engraving alphabet — its monoline, squarish letters exist so a rotary/pantograph cutter can trace them, which is why mid-century panels [and NASA/Apollo consoles] look the way they do.

**Licensing:** Gorton shown via the free *non-commercial* “Gorton Digital” revival [github.com/drdnar/GortonDigital] — embedded as a specimen subset only, **not** shipped in the Panelsmith repo. News Gothic / Trade Gothic are commercial [Linotype], likewise specimen subsets. Only B612 & League Spartan [OFL] ship in the app.